

ARISTOTLE'S ELUSIVE *SUMMUM BONUM*

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I. THE MAIN QUESTION

The philosophy of Aristotle (384–322, B.C.E.) remains a beacon of our culture. But no part of Aristotle's work is more alive and compelling today than his contribution to ethics and political science—nor more relevant to the subject of the present volume. Political science, in his view, begins with ethics, and the primary task of ethics is to elucidate *human flourishing*. Aristotle brings to this topic a mind unsurpassed in the depth, keenness, and comprehensiveness of its probing.

"Which among humanly practicable goods is the *summum bonum* or highest good?" is his first and central question.¹ As we would expect, the answer he gives is rather abstract. Even so, he intends it to be informative and to provide guidance for action.² The present essay will focus on the account put forward in the *Nicomachean Ethics*, Book I, chapter 7, where Aristotle equates the *summum bonum* with "the soul's activity of excellence in a complete life."³ This compact formula sets the agenda for Aristotelian ethics, which proceeds to explicate the *summum bonum* through detailed studies of (a) the *excellences* (or *virtues*)⁴ and (b) the two most philosophically controversial components of a *complete life*, namely *friendship*⁵ and *pleasure*.⁶ Fully spelled out, the compact formula yields a conceptually rich, and substantial, ideal.

This essay will take the compact formula as given, and will not comment on the reasoning by which Aristotle arrives at it. Nor is it my present purpose to look closely at any portion of the content of his ideal. The main question addressed here is a formal one: What does it mean in the context of Aristotelian ethics to regard X as the *summum bonum*, whatever X may be? In discussing this question, we shall be led to consider the chief components of Aristotle's ideal to see how their interrelation constitutes a whole that fits the formal account of the *summum bonum*.

¹ Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics* (hereafter NE), Book I, ch. 4, 1095a15–16.

² NE I 3, 1095a5–6; II 2, 1103b26–28.

³ NE I 7, 1098a12–20; cf. 10, 1101a14–16; Aristotle, *Eudemian Ethics* (hereafter EE), Book II, ch. 1, 1219a.

⁴ NE II–VI.

⁵ NE VIII–IX.

⁶ NE VII 11–14; X 1–5.

II. SOME PERSPECTIVES

The claim that X is the *summum bonum* seems to imply that X is the good which we should strive above all to realize. But is that what the claim means? And who are the “we” to whom the supposed implication applies?

To answer these questions we shall have to distinguish two levels of practical thinking. Before proceeding to the distinction, however, it is worth pausing over the obvious point that a practicable *summum bonum* cannot become an issue on any level except to rational beings with a multiplicity of needs and aspirations, and limited powers for satisfying them—practical beings, in short. The very phrase “*summum bonum*” implies different goods, ranking one beyond the rest. However, Aristotle remarks that everyone agrees in calling the highest good “*eudaimonia*”⁷ (usually translated as “happiness,” sometimes as “flourishing”), and he himself constantly uses this appellation. The word itself does not bring us much closer to understanding what the *summum bonum* is, since people have very different notions of *eudaimonia*.⁸ But use of the latter, more colloquial, term gives Aristotle two advantages. It opens his topic to input from ordinary common sense (an important guide toward ethical wisdom, in Aristotle’s view), whereas “the highest good” sounds a decidedly academic note. And the use of “*eudaimonia*” also brings the human ideal into relation with something more than human. For *eudaimonia* was a traditional attribute of the gods.⁹ Aristotle can accept the attribution, though not because he accepts traditional portrayals of the gods. On the contrary, god, according to the Aristotelian philosopher’s understanding, is a single unbroken, perfectly self-sufficient, eternal activity of reason.¹⁰ There is no metaphysical margin here for any good except the activity itself. “*Eudaimonia*,” then, a term implying no comparison between other goods and the good which it names, is a suitable word for the divine attribute.

In Aristotle’s eyes it is very significant that common sense recognizes the possibility of human *eudaimonia* too.¹¹ It surely is remarkable that the same word should be so naturally used both of the divine good, essential and unique in the divine life, and of a human good which is best among many and attainable only through the hazards of practicality.

We are already, with Aristotle, reflecting in a way that may seem out of place for the practical beings we are. From a “purely” practical point of view, as it might be called, our practical nature goes without saying.

⁷ NE I 4, 1095a17–20.

⁸ NE I 4, 1095a20–28.

⁹ NE X 8, 1178b8–9.

¹⁰ NE X 8, 1178b9–22; Aristotle, *Metaphysics*, Book XII, chs. 7 and 9.

¹¹ The well-being of nonrational animals is not *eudaimonia*; see EE I 7, 1217a20–29; NE I 9, 1099b32–1100a1; X 8, 1178b25–28.

When engaged in practical action we occupy the practical point of view, which like any perspective simply assumes its occupants as such. But Aristotle's ethics is built on a cosmic anthropology in which distinctively human existence is compared with other forms of life. We have just seen how the truism that the *summum bonum* is *eudaimonia* implies a comparison between human good and divine. The difference between human and divine invites, in turn, the comparison of humans with nonrational animals.¹² From the cosmic point of view it may even be cause for wonder that beings like ourselves exist at all to puzzle over how the capacity for godlike *eudaimonia* can occur interwoven with the needs of a vulnerable organism making its way in a physical environment. (Since the human organism makes its way only by learning, and we learn only from others of our kind, our way is essentially social,¹³ which adds further dimensions of complexity to the multiple nature of the human good.) This cosmic-anthropological standpoint does not allow us to take our practical essence for granted.

Leaving wonder aside, however, there are also down-to-earth reasons why our practicality is not just a topic of speculation but for us an object of intense *practical* concern. The contrast just made between a practical perspective which takes itself wholly for granted, and the cosmological view which reflects upon the former, is compelling only if we ignore human nature and assume (legitimately, perhaps, for certain theoretical purposes) that as practical beings we are all committed to making good practical decisions, capable of discerning them, and geared to carrying them out. Were the assumptions true in practice, our practical decision-making could, of course, afford to overlook its own basis in the requisite organization of the soul. Practicality then might never have become a topic. (By the same token, when ethical theory confines itself to a universe of discourse where all agents are actively rational, the shift to an external perspective such as that of cosmic anthropology will seem gratuitous for ethics.) But since it is equally plain that the assumptions are false in practice and that we need them to be at least roughly true if only to satisfy our most obvious requirements, the cultivation of practical rationality becomes a pressing concern for the practical beings we are. The resulting reflection, along with experience, may even lead us to conclude that practical rationality, our paramount resource for obtaining the other things which we value, is best secured by means of the belief that in achieving it we achieve an *intrinsic* good, whether or not this belief is independently grounded or even meaningful. Inevitably, efforts to sustain and teach this conviction will sometimes be displaced by philosophical misgivings. How is it consistent with our *general* rationality to nurture our practical reason on a possibly irrational belief? In this way, a realistic practical point of

¹² See previous note; see also *NE* I 7, 1098a1–3.

¹³ *NE* I 7, 1097b6–11; IX 9, 1169b18–19.

view naturally opens into a perspective every bit as external to practicality itself as the perspective of cosmic anthropology.

Whether we take good practice to be simply a resource for achieving other goods or an end in itself, it poses a special kind of practical problem because of the special way in which its reality is contingent and within our power. It is not in our power as an external good is when close enough for us to lay hands on it or when we have the legal right to use it. "Possessing" good practical agency essentially depends on the would-be possessor's commitment¹⁴ to being a certain sort of person. Where others are concerned, we can create conditions favoring such commitment, but cannot inject the commitment itself. And since commitment is not an external precondition but the core of good practical agency, the latter's reality is contingent in a peculiar way. It is self-developing and self-sustaining to the extent that commitment is present, and this fact, considered by itself, seems to place good agency in the class of things which belong necessarily to their subjects given that they belong at all. To the extent that commitment to it is lacking, good agency cannot install itself any more than it can be installed from outside: which seems to place it in the corresponding class of impossibilities. Since according to Aristotle we begin neither as clear-cut haves nor as clear-cut have-nots in this respect, but can develop in either direction,¹⁵ the initial stages are critical, taking us further and further away from alternative possibilities.¹⁶ And since individuals develop by absorbing the values of those around them, and will pass them on in the same way, the self-propagating structure of good and bad practice is found at the collective level too, in families and communities.

There is plenty in these distinctively human facts to interest the cosmic anthropologist, but in the *Nicomachean Ethics* Aristotle's interest is practical: he lays out the facts so as to educate moral educators in the fundamentals of their task. Perhaps as a moralist and educator Aristotle could not afford to pause in puzzlement at the phenomena of human imperfection; but the anthropologist should surely wonder at some of them, especially an anthropologist who, like Aristotle in his scientific studies, operates under the assumption that "nature does nothing in vain."¹⁷ For instance, if we are essentially practical rational beings, how is it that sometimes we fling ourselves into irrationality with such welcoming gusto even in the teeth of its destructiveness? The Greek poets speak of Eros and Ate sent by the gods, but experience knows that transports of lust or rage do not always swoop upon us as if from outside. Often it is as if we willfully release such forces, fueling them from within as though we find ourselves in being consumed. Afterward we say: "I was not myself"; but

¹⁴ Thus, Aristotle commonly uses "*spoudaios*" (literally: "serious") to mean "morally good."

¹⁵ NE II 1, 1103a18–26.

¹⁶ NE III 5, 1114a12–18.

¹⁷ See, e.g., Aristotle, *Generation of Animals*, Book V, ch. 8, 788b21.

is it true? According to the Bible, "the imagination of man's heart is evil from his youth";¹⁸ psychoanalysis has its own explanations; common sense talks of immaturity while acknowledging the need for an occasional vacation from responsibility. A suggestion which paves the way toward an Aristotelian response would be that what we seek when we kick over the traces of practical rationality is the taste of a fantasy *summum bonum*: a state of pure abandonment in the immunity of knowing that nothing else matters or even exists beyond some immediate enthralling object, whatever it may be.

We meet this human propensity with efforts to repress, contain, and sublimate. By themselves, though, such responses fail to come to terms with the fantasy *summum bonum*'s claim to be our *summum bonum*. The claim has power because it seems to ring true. Hence, various attempts have been made to take it seriously. In each case, the claim is acknowledged to represent an ideal of perfect fulfillment, and some form of approximation is recommended. One type of approach, emphasizing satisfaction rather than ecstasy, looks to raise the ratio of the individual's fulfilled to unfulfilled desires. This can be done either by keeping desires constant and finding surer ways of implementation, or by leaving the facts as they are and adjusting desires to whatever is at hand.

But an Aristotelian response would not follow either of these routes. Instead, it would begin by figuring out what sort of being one would have to be to live in perfect fulfillment. It would see that one would have to be independent of the mercy of circumstance. No needs could distract one, so one's only need (if so it can be called) would be for the fulfilling activity. One would not be beholden to a physical or social environment, but would constitute one's own company, one's own sustenance and instrumentation. One would be immortal, because one's activity could not fail unless the very love of life were to fail from within, which seems incompatible with perfect fulfillment. Fulfillment for such a being must consist in an activity suitable to its nature: an activity, therefore, that is endlessly interesting and perfectly self-contained. What has just been described is the life of a god, according to Aristotle's understanding.

Thus, if humans need sometimes to escape from practicality, not in order to fall asleep but because we crave positive engagement free from practical constraints, we have a model for the kind of activity in which it makes sense to seek liberation. The model is divine activity: free, self-sufficient, untouched by anything external. It hardly seems to matter for this argument whether we suppose this paradigm to be something real or only conceptual. Either way, Aristotle takes it seriously in practice when he fashions his famous defense of human theoretical reasoning ("contemplation"), arguing that we are at our most godlike in this purely intellectual activity, which shapes itself from within and seeks no satisfaction

¹⁸ Genesis 8:21.

beyond itself.¹⁹ Against those who caution mortals not to aspire beyond their mortal level, Aristotle encourages us to “act immortal” so far as our lives permit.²⁰ In this, he—and we, if we resonate to these intimations—have gone some way toward acknowledging the claim of what above was termed “the fantasy *summum bonum*.”

We are thereby led to recognize intellectual, or spiritual, or imaginative, activity for its own sake as a fundamental human good. A much more careful argument would be needed to support the position that such activity should be accorded the status of *highest* human good. In any case, this essay has yet to consider what a claim of this stronger form would mean. But the weaker conclusion is not necessarily less significant for anthropology and for education.

In the light of what has emerged so far, Aristotle’s contribution to ethics can be seen as a double corrective for ethical theorizing that centers on what was earlier labeled the “purely practical” point of view. Such an approach takes for granted our reality as practical beings and our commitment to whatever is to count as practical success. It considers what principles a rational decider should use; how they should be applied; how they can be justified; whether they can be defended as objectively valid or binding on everyone; whether principles of morality take precedence over other kinds of principle, and if so, why they do. These, along with questions about the principles of justice, are still frequently assumed to be definitive of the field of philosophical ethics. Yet in Aristotle’s ethical thinking these problems are not in the forefront. On the contrary, *his* two great problems reflect fundamental limitations of the purely practical perspective. The latter depends for its existence, just as studies which assume it depend for their practical relevance, on a not automatically guaranteed supply of good practical agents: hence the problem of moral education. Nor can the perspective, or studies which assume it, begin to confront, as a question for ethics, the problem of what we should do with ourselves when not called upon to be practical.

III. WHAT IS IT FOR X TO BE THE *SUMMUM BONUM*?

A. A utilitarian answer

The theory of utilitarianism has shaped the course of debate among Western moral philosophers for more than two hundred years. So it is natural for us to understand the question “What is the human *summum bonum*?” in the way in which John Stuart Mill seems to understand it in the opening pages of his monograph *Utilitarianism*. Mill takes the question to expect an answer specifying *the good which we should strive above all*

¹⁹ NE X 6–8; *Metaphysics* I 2; *Protrepticus* B 23–28 (Düring).

²⁰ NE X 7, 1177b31–34.

to realize, and he assumes that specifying this is the same as specifying "the criterion of right and wrong," which he also calls "the foundation of morality." Thus, he writes:

From the dawn of philosophy, the question concerning the *summum bonum*, or, what is the same thing, concerning the foundation of morality, has been accounted the main problem in speculative thought, has occupied the most gifted intellects, and divided them into sects and schools, carrying on a vigorous warfare against one another. And after more than two thousand years the same discussions continue. . . .²¹

This passage suggests a certain conception of what it is for X to figure as the *summum bonum*. It is for X to be one's ultimate objective, providing a universal rule for deciding what to do, namely: Strive to realize X.²²

Is this conception Aristotelian? Before trying to answer, we should note that if (with Mill and Aristotle) one accepts that there is (in a practical sense) such a thing as the *summum bonum*, and further accepts the formal conception just outlined, one will be pulled (irresistibly, is another question) in the direction of the distinctively utilitarian substantial characterization of the *summum bonum* as general happiness or welfare, or the happiness/welfare "of the greatest number," however this is interpreted. Or rather, one will feel the pull if, like Aristotle and Mill, one has a good measure of respect for the ordinary moral consciousness; and one will not feel it if, flouting the latter, one believes that one's own happiness should be the one overriding goal, or that each individual's happiness should be the one goal for him or her. If there really is just one universal rule for me to follow in deciding what to do, and it is a rule referring to happiness or well-being (rather than to rationality as such, as with Kant), then unless I am an ethical egoist it will have to be a rule that refers to the happiness or well-being of a field of persons: my group, or all those whom my action might affect. For although this carries some paradoxical consequences for common sense, the package is less odious than the egoist alternative. Thus, the utilitarian *summum bonum* is a good which consists in a suitably extensive interpersonal multiplication of some other good such as well-being or happiness. But as we shall see, Aristotle does not think of the *summum bonum* as multiple in this way. In the light of the reasoning just given, this is evidence of his not sharing the formal conception of the *summum bonum* suggested by the above quotation from Mill's *Utilitarianism*.

²¹ J. S. Mill, "Utilitarianism," in *Mill's Ethical Writings*, ed. J. B. Schneewind (New York: Macmillan, 1965), pp. 75–76.

²² It is not clear whether Mill in fact takes this to be the formal meaning of "*summum bonum*," or whether he even considers the question of the formal meaning.

Turning now directly to Aristotle, we must distinguish two levels of practical thinking: (1) that of the “statesman”²³ (*politikos*), whose chief task, in Aristotle’s view, is to set and preserve values and principles, and shape accordingly the lives of those for whom he or she is responsible; and (2) that of the “individual” whose life is so shaped. It is a difference of roles, not persons. A statesman is an individual simultaneously, and in political constitutions where offices rotate, leaders revert to being mere individuals. For Aristotle, the paradigmatic statesman is, of course, the political leader, but the obligation to engage in the kind of thinking (*politikê*) that typifies the statesman is not confined to those who occupy or expect to occupy political office. The thinking in question may be described as “fundamental policymaking.” It involves not only ethical reflection but planning in accordance with the values endorsed. Thus, the head of a family is or should be a “statesman” in relation to those under his or her responsibility, and every free adult should keep a statesmanly eye on his or her own life. The “individual,” by contrast, is the person regarded as actually living out the detail of the life thus planned.

I turn now to the question whether Aristotle conceives of the *summum bonum* as that which one should strive above all to realize. If the question is posed with reference to the statesman, the answer turns out to be “No, but . . .” In other words, an affirmative answer would not be wholly misleading. Insofar as “Yes” implies or suggests that, according to Aristotle, the agent (on this level, the statesman) should make every decision with a view to realizing the *summum bonum*, “Yes” conveys the truth. But it also carries the false implication that the Aristotelian *summum bonum* owes its status as such to the way in which it figures in the good statesman’s decision-making. If, on the other hand, the question is posed with reference to the individual, the answer is a definite “No.” Not only is the affirmative false itself, but so is its implication that the individual ought to make every decision with a view to realizing the *summum bonum*.

So far, these are only summary conclusions. For clarification, let us turn first to Book I, chapter 2 of the *Nicomachean Ethics*, where Aristotle speaks of the *summum bonum* as the “goal (*telos*) of what we do, which we desire for its own sake, everything else being desired for the sake of it.”²⁴ Within a few lines it becomes apparent that this is the goal of ideal statesmanship, the architectonic expertise which regulates the other goods in life in order to promote the *summum bonum*.²⁵ The philosopher’s task is to explain the latter’s nature so that statesmanship may aim at its target more effectively.²⁶ Just such a view of the philosopher’s task would be taken “after more than two thousand years” by Jeremy Bentham, the founder of

²³ This word and its clumsy adjectives are high-flown and sexist, but less misleading than the alternative, “politician” and its cognates.

²⁴ NE I 2, 1094a18–19.

²⁵ NE I 2, 1094a26–b11; I 13, 1102a5–10.

²⁶ NE I 2, 1094a22–24.

utilitarianism, and by J. S. Mill.²⁷ But there is a crucial difference. Immediately after declaring the *summum bonum* to be the goal of statesmanship, Aristotle speaks of it as "the same, whether it is for a single individual or for a *polis* (city-state)." He then concedes that realizing it over a wide field (the wider, the better; it might even consist of many *poleis* or the whole Hellenic world) is "greater and more ideal," and "nobler and more god-like," although bringing it about for one person is not at all to be despised.²⁸ This tells us that the definitive goal of Aristotelian statesmanship is not a suitably extended interpersonal maximum of some given sort of good, but is itself a good of some sort which may be widely or narrowly realized. Statesmanship stands to its goal as the art of medicine stands to its goal, health. Medical knowledge does not dictate whom to heal or how many (except in the special case where patients reinfect one another unless all are treated); and the same is true of statesmanship. According to this system of concepts, the superiority of the *summum bonum* to all other goods is grounded on its nature (which has not yet been explained), not on its being the most extensive occurrence of a good which might also occur less extensively. Moreover, "Realize the *summum bonum*" is the rule governing the Aristotelian statesman's actions as such; but it is not *qua* statesman in Aristotle's sense that the practitioner undertakes to operate on a larger or smaller scale. Who and how many should constitute the field of operation depends on the practitioner's circumstances as an *individual*. (Thus, it is to the statesman or would-be statesman as *individual* that Aristotle addresses the comment that it is greater and more ideal, etc., to realize the *summum bonum* for many than for one.)

The fact that, in Aristotle's view, the *summum bonum* is the defining goal of statesmanship may lead one to think that, for Aristotle, this is what it is for X to be the *summum bonum*: it is for X to figure as the goal of the statesman as such. But the conclusion does not follow. Moreover, it denies Aristotle a reasonable explanation for why the statesman should seek to promote whatever it is that the *summum bonum* will turn out to be. Surely it is *because* X is the *summum bonum* that promoting X is the special responsibility of those with the power or expertise for managing the ordinary or well-known goods. But if so, to say that X is the *summum bonum* is to say something more than: "X is the goal that should govern the statesman's every action."

Let us now turn to what it is that the Aristotelian statesman tries to realize. Here we move to the other level of practical thinking, that of the "individual." For the statesman cannot directly produce the end of statecraft, because it consists in the happiness (*eudaimonia*) of those for whom he or she is responsible, and Aristotelian happiness, we are told, is "the

²⁷ Witness the title of Bentham's seminal *An Introduction to the Principles of Morals and Legislation* (1789). Mill, too, addressed policymakers and individuals, without distinction.

²⁸ NE I 2, 1094b7–10.

activity of excellence in a complete life.”²⁹ “Excellence” here means that of a human being as such, considered not as a biological system but as rational and practical. Aristotle recognizes many excellences of *character* (also known as the “moral excellences”), as, for example, courage, good temper, highmindedness, justice; and he also recognizes two great excellences of *intellect*, namely, practical wisdom and theoretic cultivation. “Complete” implies a life of reasonable span, adequately blessed with health, material goods, the respect of others, friends, a satisfactory family, enjoyable pursuits, and perhaps other things that people generally regard as desirable. The statesman cannot directly produce an individual’s happiness in the way in which a potter can produce a pot for someone, because several of the goods constituting Aristotelian happiness are or involve *activities* which (like the commitment spoken of earlier, in Section II) depend for their existence on the individual’s participation. The statesman can do no more than create conditions for happiness.

Now we must ask: According to Aristotle, does the *summum bonum* enter into the life of the individual in the same way as it enters into the life of the statesman, that is, by being what the individual should essentially aim to bring about in as many lives as he or she happens to be responsible for in some measure? The answer depends on how Aristotle understands the individual’s practical activity. Since this activity, issuing from practical excellence, is a major component of the complex good which is happiness and the *summum bonum*, our question collapses into the following: Insofar as happiness consists in the individual’s practical activity of excellence, and insofar as the statesman’s defining goal is to promote happiness, is it the statesman’s defining task, according to Aristotle, to promote good *statesmanly* activity on the part of individuals? If so, then Aristotle must hold that the individual’s practical activity of excellence is entirely structured by decisions governed by the one great principle of statecraft, interpreted as the philosophically enlightened statesman interprets it.

This is clearly not Aristotle’s view, however. Promoting conditions for happiness, one’s own and the happiness of those around one, is obviously an important concern for the person of practical excellence (who should also have a sound grasp of what in fact counts toward happiness in a given situation). But Aristotle does not present this as the person’s one paramount goal.³⁰ Far from portraying the wise individual as acting always in accordance with a single rule, Aristotle warns his readers not to expect absolutely firm rules of practice.³¹ (The person of practical excellence is always concerned to make good decisions, but “Make a good [or the right] decision” is not a rule that can help determine what a wise

²⁹ NE I 7, 1098a16–18.

³⁰ For a detailed interpretation, see Sarah Broadie, *Ethics with Aristotle* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1991), pp. 198–202.

³¹ NE II 2, 1104a1–10.

decision would be.) Aristotle's discussions of the various excellences point in the same direction. The just person acts from considerations of fairness, which is determined by reference to desert and proportionality.³² Promoting the conditions for happiness is not, as such, a mark of the just action. The courageous individual faces necessary danger in battle simply because it is his duty and anything else would be shameful.³³ (By contrast, statesmanship—in abeyance in the thick of the battle—should be able to justify the decision to go to war, by reference to the *summum bonum*.) There is no suggestion that the person of “tasteful wit” (*eutrapelia*, one of the Aristotelian virtues of character) enlivens conversation with pleasures crafted with a view to promoting the conditions for happiness.³⁴ Again, in discussing practical wisdom Aristotle says that while practical wisdom perceives the means, excellence of character is what “makes the end right.”³⁵ But excellence of character develops through upbringing and good conduct, not through philosophizing.³⁶ Statesmanship, by contrast, depends on philosophy to elucidate its goal.³⁷ If individual practical excellence is defined by aiming at happiness in the way in which good statesmanship is, then either the good statesman (presumably also an excellent individual) does not need Aristotle's ethical system to help “make the end right,” or mere excellence of character is not, after all, sufficient for this function in the case of the individual. Either way, Aristotle's teaching is inconsistent.

B. An Aristotelian answer

The following results have just been reached: (a) if X is the *summum bonum*, then “Realize X” is the rule governing the Aristotelian statesman's every decision; but (b) this is not what it is for X to be the *summum bonum*; and (c) no such rule governs the good individual's every practical response. From this, a question arises. On the level of the statesman, we can see the relation of X to the other goods: it is the end to be achieved by managing them with a view to precisely that. But how does X stand in relation to the other goods in the life of the individual? And how does it enter into and (so to speak) affect that life if not by figuring as the end to be sought in all one's practical decision-making? To answer this is to answer our main question: (In the context of Aristotle's ethics) what is it for X to be the *summum bonum*? This is because the statesman seeks to craft the *summum bonum* not for himself, the statesman, as such, but for

³² NE V 3–5.

³³ NE III 7, 1115b11–12; 8, 1116b2–3.

³⁴ NE IV 8.

³⁵ NE VI 13, 1145a4–6; cf. NE VI 12, 1144a6–9, 20–22, 31–36.

³⁶ NE II 4, 1105b9–18; X 9, 1179a36–b34.

³⁷ NE I 2, 1094a22–25.

the individual. The individual, in other words, is the locus of the Aristotelian *summum bonum*. Consequently, the relation of X to the other goods in the life of the individual is the relation to them which constitutes X the *summum bonum*.

According to Aristotle's understanding, for X to be the *summum bonum* is for it to be "the principle and the cause of the [other] goods."³⁸ This is not to be taken as implying that the *summum bonum*, whatever it is, causes the existence of goods such as health and wealth and friendly connections, thereby doing duty for the ordinary causes of these things, such as exercise, prudent management of resources, and willingness to cooperate. The meaning, rather, is that the relation to the other goods which constitutes X *summum* is that of rendering them good and worth having, and therefore worthy of past efforts to obtain and present concerns to preserve. (All this is on the level of the individual.) Now, although Aristotle notes it as a point in favor of his own position that everyone speaks of happiness as the highest good, his reason for accepting this identification is somewhat esoteric. It is that once we understand happiness for what it is—that is, once we understand it as activity of excellence in a complete life—we see why happiness is the *summum bonum*. It is because activity of excellence in relation to the various elements contributing to completeness of life is what makes those objects worth having.

Asked, "What is the highest good?" a person might answer: "Pleasure," or: "Love and friendship." It would be one kind of mistake to maintain this seriously without qualification; some pleasures, some kinds of love and friendship, are destructive, degrading, corrupting, etc. Faced with plausible examples, the respondent might agree. In that case his or her natural next move would be to modify the original claim to (for example): "The highest good is *worthwhile* love and friendship." But a philosopher would see this as embodying another mistake: the failure to grasp what is at issue in claiming so-and-so to be the highest good. Perhaps the respondent means: "It is what everyone should value most." It might even be correct to say this of worthwhile love and friendship. But even if so, worthwhile love and friendship cannot be the *summum bonum* according to the philosopher's understanding. If some forms of love and friendship are worthwhile, it is because of something about them over and above the features that bring them under a general definition of love and friendship. This something else is what makes good love and friendship good; they do not make themselves so. Hence, the something else, not they, performs the role of *summum bonum*. This argument can be generalized to show that the *summum bonum*, whatever it is, cannot be a good form of something of which bad forms are also possible. Activity of

³⁸ NE I 12, 1102a2–4; cf. NE I 4, 1095a26–28 (reporting a position which Aristotle does not reject although he rejects the Platonist interpretation of it; see EE I 8, especially 1218b7–14).

excellence in a complete life fills the bill (as does activity of excellence *tout court*). This cannot take bad forms; hence, it is superfluous to call any of its forms good.

The idea, then, is that activity of excellence in relation to the elements of a complete life, whether severally or together, is what makes those so-called advantages worth having. I say "so-called," because, although everyone wants them and acts and feels about them as if they are worth having and would contribute to happiness, outside the context of actual or assured activity of excellence, they are, at most, conditional promises of advantage. Activity of excellence, actual or assured, discharges the condition. It provides, as it were, a field—we could call it the "eudaimonic field"—in which those items take on the substantiality of goodness and count as ingredients of genuine happiness.³⁹

But how does this come about? The point for which we now seek explanation is summed up in Aristotle's doctrine that "the good man [i.e., the person of excellence] is the measuring rod in matters of value."⁴⁰ This is by contrast with those of the opposite stamp. They, it turns out, are mistaken in valuing the things which everyone wants; or more precisely: they are mistaken in thinking those things worth having, when their own having them is meant. Certainly they think that if they pursue something as worth having (why else pursue it?), the thing is not going to lose its value once they have it. Otherwise they would not be better off then, as of course they think they will be. But will they? Go to the person of excellence. He or she contemplates the activities of one who does not merely fall short (the contemplator, too, may be less than perfect) but is facing in this or that wrong direction for developing excellence. In the eyes of the contemplator, the other's life is not desirable. The contemplator would not (even could not) live that way on any terms. Now suppose this contemplated agent is seen as achieving some of the usual desiderata, or as possessing them perhaps to an exceptional degree, or as operating through or about them to his or her pleasure or satisfaction. We ask the person of excellence: "Is that life now more desirable because of the feature which has just appeared?" If the latter wavers, we press: "Would *you* want that success or satisfaction on those terms—i.e., as part of a life like that?" The predictable negative answer implies that, according to the person of excellence, the contemplated life is not more desirable when it includes the usual desiderata than when it lacks them. Thus, according to the person of excellence, the one who lives that life is no better off with them than without them. For how could one *be better off* with X, yet *live no better* having X than not? So according to the person of excellence (who is a true measure), the usual desiderata are worthless insofar as they

³⁹ Cf. *EE* VIII 3, 1248b26ff.: "The good person is one for whom the natural goods are good." For a fuller development of the theme, see Plato, *Euthydemus*, 280b–282e.

⁴⁰ *NE* III 4, 1113a25–33.

relate to the contemplated agent as constituents, actual or possible, of *such an agent's life*.⁴¹

But does the negative judgment passed by the person of excellence somehow make it the case that the other life and the goods in it are worthless? Does the person of excellence rule this fact into being? One can see how Aristotle would reply to this, even though it is not easy for us to see how we could get back to the point—if we even wanted to—from which it would also be our considered reply as philosophers. Aristotle would say: “The person of excellence judges as he does because of what he sees about the other’s life. He sees confusion of values: means being prized as if they were ends, ends precious in themselves exploited as means. He sees opportunities for good being missed through failure to understand the kind of good they are opportunities for—hence, in relation to this agent, they were never really opportunities. Since an opportunity for good is itself, as such, a category of good,⁴² here we have an example of how the agent’s personality cancels the value (so far as he himself is concerned) of a good which is present in his life. The person of excellence sees all this in the *activities* of the agent contemplated. He sees them as they are. *What* he sees is what leads him to form his judgment, and what he sees makes that judgment true. Thus, the so-called good things in the contemplated life are not worthless because the person of excellence thinks so. They are made worthless by the activity—its character and limitations—of the agent concerned. By contrast, an agent of opposite character makes worthwhile the goods in his life by acting about them in appropriate ways.”

Obviously there can be no ground for congratulating a person on reaching some desired objective, or on a piece of good fortune, if he or she is in fact no better off. The same applies to self-congratulation or disappointment when one fares badly. If each is the final judge of his own worth, then the truth in these matters is as each sees it; getting what one wants is success and brings one closer to happiness. But if we can be blind to our human failings (the alternatives to blindness being: [1] we are free of such failings, and [2] we have them in full awareness of them and their nature as *failings*), then one who is blind in this way, yet cares about having the things which everyone finds desirable, lives in a dream. In reality, according to the present metaphysic of morals, there is for this agent no practical difference between failure and success in obtaining or keeping those things. I cannot lose an advantage the gaining of which would have brought no benefit to the person living *my* life. Disappoint-

⁴¹ It is to be emphasized that this is intended as an analysis of what is implied by judging another to be of a character such that one would not be him no matter what advantages (as usually understood) might be attached. It is a further question whether such an undiluted attitude exists or should exist, even in the “good person.”

⁴² NE I 6, 1096a23–33.

ment and satisfaction at how things go for me presuppose my worth, actually or probably expressing itself in activity of excellence. For beings such as us, essentially practical, it is a chilling possibility that instead of its mattering how things turn out for us, we operate unknown to ourselves in a dark where success and failure are the same, ourselves rendering our efforts pointless at source. Nor, for such beings, could there be any more pressing necessity than that of ensuring the truth, more or less, of the practical assumption of our own worth which all our projects imply.

On this account, the *summum bonum*, so far as it consists in activity of excellence, is not primarily a good whose conditions we ought to act in order to secure. To the extent that it is true that we ought to act in order to secure it (different extents for individual and statesman), this truth follows from the more fundamental fact that the *summum bonum*, so far as it consists in activity of excellence, is the *sine qua non* of its mattering whether we secure anything else at all.

IV. IS THE *SUMMUM BONUM* NO MORE THAN ACTIVITY OF EXCELLENCE?

In using the expression "the *summum bonum*, so far as it consists in activity of excellence," we seem on the brink of treating activity of excellence as identical with Aristotle's *summum bonum*. It is true that activity of excellence becomes happiness in the presence of the other elements (the ones making up a complete life), while they in turn, if sufficiently provided, become happiness in the presence of it. But these contributions to happiness are not symmetrical. Activity of excellence contributes by being already, from its own nature, unconditionally good. That is why it can make the otherwise valueless others good, rendering them constituents of a way of being which is properly called "happiness."

Activity of excellence, then, is a good not itself made good by happiness; it is prior to happiness and more fundamental. In view of this priority, as well as the fact that activity of excellence plays the principal role in the constitution of happiness (figuring as the metaphysical "agent" of good in relation to the "passive" other elements), one may be tempted to conclude that the *summum bonum* is activity of excellence *tout court*. This conclusion seems reinforced by the fact that Aristotle would certainly not want to say that goods which support activity of excellence even when there is no hope of its becoming happiness (through lack of some important component of the complete life) are therefore not worth having. Activity of excellence as such is good-making. Is it, then, rather than happiness, the *summum bonum*? Or is it identical with happiness? Neither alternative represents Aristotle's view. He not only repeatedly refers to the *summum bonum* as "happiness," but rejects any general iden-

tification of happiness with activity of excellence.⁴³ A happy individual, he says, is not "dislodged" from happiness except by major misfortune: but it can happen, and unless the person is killed or disabled, he or she continues in activities of excellence, making the best of harsh circumstances.⁴⁴

Two points are relevant here. Firstly, Aristotle's ultimate paradigm of happiness is god. It might seem out of place to speak of the divine activity as "excellent," as if to exclude an alternative possibility. But, at any rate, since it is perfectly self-sufficient, happiness necessarily coincides with activity in this limiting case. Secondly, on the human level there is qualitative continuity between merely excellent activity, and happy activity, since the former, even at its most austere, depends on some measure of the other goods. One cannot exercise excellences such as temperance and justice except in relation to goods such as food and fellow-citizens.⁴⁵ And one must have the necessities of life to act at all. (Hence, there are, presumably, degrees of happiness. A person might lack one of the important elements of a complete life—for example, if he were blind—yet still count as happy rather than not.)⁴⁶ But the two points may pull in opposite directions if either is made a ground for identifying human happiness with human excellent activity *tout court*. The comparison with god could be drawn so as to suggest that humans are happiest when their excellent activity involves the minimum of other goods. (But what if one would welcome more of them? If so, one's dissatisfaction with the status quo would have to be interpreted as failure to recognize or fully appreciate one's happiness.) By contrast, the second point suggests the argument: mere excellent activity differs from conspicuous happiness only by degrees; so the former is happiness too. But since the degrees increase with the amount or number of other goods present (up to the point of superfluity), this argument indicates that our happiness is greater the less its structure approximates god's by minimal dependence on factors other than excellent activity.

The main difficulty of equating the *summum bonum* with activity of excellence *tout court* is that, on these terms, no one can reasonably want a good whose absence does not hamper his or her excellent activity, but whose presence would make it easier, say, or more enjoyable. For if the presence of the thing is superfluous so far as the subject's actual engagement in excellent activity is concerned, the thing is not part of his or her happiness, and should count as not worth having. Some philosophers

⁴³ This seems clear notwithstanding Richard Kraut's arguments to the contrary in his *Aristotle on the Human Good* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1989).

⁴⁴ NE I 10, 1100b22–1101a11.

⁴⁵ NE X 8, 1178a28–33.

⁴⁶ The example is from Gavin Lawrence, "Nonaggregatability, Inclusiveness, and the Theory of Focal Value: *Nicomachean Ethics* I.7. 1097b16–20," *Phronesis*, vol. 42, no. 1 (1997), pp. 32ff.

have defended the equation, even accepting the paradoxical conclusion just drawn, but Aristotle is not among them. Again, it would be strange to argue (if anyone has) that a person actively excellent but living in poverty should welcome improved circumstances not because prosperity contributes to one's happiness, but because it makes one more satisfied with the happiness one already exemplifies! If contentment is necessary for happiness, the argument falls short of showing that even the pauper's activity of excellence should count as happiness; and if it is not, the right-minded pauper has no business seeking to become less needy. But according to Aristotle, if in fact such a pauper wishes for, hopes for, tries for, welcomes improvement of his condition, these attitudes are entirely appropriate as attitudes of *this* person toward *this* person's situation and prospects, for (as before) in matters of value "the good man is the measure."

Obviously, difficult circumstances can make the activity of excellence harder for the subject. But that does not necessarily render it shorter or less frequent. Hardship stimulates greater activity of excellence in those who can rise to the challenge. Should they then embrace the hardship? One can hardly say "Yes," since this concession implies that one who looks back on an episode in which he rightly (as he believed then and still believes) refused under torture to betray his country's secrets, should, if he has proper values, treasure the event as an episode of *happiness* (and should wish happiness for those he loves?). Alternatively, it might be argued that the actively excellent person has reason to welcome better circumstances (as we normally call them) in that now he or she can be actively excellent in more contexts or bring more excellences into play. Certainly, this may be one's reason (and if so, surely a good one) for preferring to be free of hardship or privation. It is not the only good reason, however. Over and above that sort of reason for looking forward to having his sight again, the cataract patient looks forward to the pleasure of seeing well, of exercising the faculty of vision. This natural faculty is not an "excellence" in the sense relevant for Aristotle's ethics. The activity of vision is desirable per se as well as for facilitating other activities, including activities of excellence.⁴⁷ But it is not desirable per se because it is an activity of excellence itself. How do we know that it is desirable per se? We know from the fact that the good person, like everyone else, values it for what it is.

All practical activities aim to produce an ulterior result, but there is an important distinction which Aristotle might have said more to emphasize. In one sort of case, we aim to produce a result mainly as a basis for further activity of the same kind—for instance, farming, which is a way of life. In the other kind of case, the desired result will displace the circumstances which made the original activity necessary or possible—

⁴⁷ NE I 6, 1096b17–19; *Metaphysics* I 1, 980a20–28.

for instance, fighting a war for the sake of peace with security.⁴⁸ In times of peace, gentler excellences should come into play, upstaging those that show themselves most in times of crisis and austerity. No doubt peace-time offers more choices, but it would be difficult to make the case that the excellent activities of peace are necessarily more numerous or open to more individuals, or show greater or more various excellence, than their wartime counterparts. The rational desire for peace on the right terms is not grounded on the prospect of more, or more excellent, excellent activity, but on the distinct prospect of a happier way of life. The difference is made by such factors as freedom from fear, and from stress, privation, and hardship. Activity of excellence carried on under such conditions is more desirable than activity of excellence carried on in their absence—because of the character of the conditions themselves, not because they add to the sum of excellent activity. That they add to it is, as a general claim, much less obvious than that peace is preferable to war. It is preferable because of the independent natures of war and peace themselves. These independent natures do not, of course, make peace unconditionally more desirable than war. It still remains true that in the absence of suitable activities of excellence, peace will not have been worth fighting for.

Happiness, then, differs from activity of excellence. Each is an unconditional good that makes good the elements necessary for it. But happiness is unique in making good the objects necessary for activity of excellence and other objects universally desired.

V. IN CONCLUSION

Finally, I want to offer two concluding reflections, one practical, one metaphysical.

1. It is a particularly important task of statesmanship, in changing times, to prepare individuals to switch into newly appropriate modes of excellent activity. The point about war and peace is good in itself, but Aristotle also brings it forward as an analogy for business and leisure.⁴⁹ Our natural desire for leisure will turn out to have been for something pointless to attain unless we are morally and intellectually equipped to employ it in suitable activities of excellence. Suitable activity, Aristotle argues, would be the kind of activity it makes most sense to ascribe to beings beyond the need of the special conditions that make leisure a human possibility. Aristotle recommends such activity precisely because it is godlike⁵⁰ (even more so, he thinks, than beneficent statesmanship on a grand scale). But the recommendation need not depend on theological

⁴⁸ NE X 7, 1177b4–12.

⁴⁹ See the previous note; see also Aristotle, *Politics*, Book VII, ch. 14, 1333a30–b11, and Book VIII, ch. 3, 1337b29–1338a13.

⁵⁰ NE X 7, 1177b19–34; 8, 1178b21–23.

assumptions or on Aristotle's conception of divinity. Leisure is a time for forgetting what had to be done to procure it, and for doing something quite different. In leisure, we act as if the infrastructure has nothing to do with us. It is not unreasonable, then, to choose leisure activities approximating those of absolutely free beings, whether or not such beings exist or are properly reckoned divine. In any case, worthwhile leisure activity is one way of instantiating the *summum bonum*. Engaged in it, we make the other goods worth having: both leisure itself, and the economic and social resources on which it depends.

2. It remains to respond to the metaphysical impulse that identifies the *summum bonum* with activity of excellence *tout court* on the ground that activity of excellence plays the leading part in the constitution of happiness. One response gives in to the impulse, respects Aristotle's equation of *summum bonum* with happiness, and consequently identifies happiness with activity of excellence. We have seen the difficulties of that. Another response would be to give in to the impulse, distinguish happiness and activity of excellence, and conclude *pace* Aristotle that happiness is not the Aristotelian *summum bonum*. But the impulse is not well founded. The unconditional good which is activity of excellence is prior to the good which is happiness. Because of this priority, activity of excellence *can* give worth to other things generally desired, and *would* give them worth *given that* they are available. But the prior good is not, because prior, the *summum bonum*, if the *summum bonum* is the good that *gives* worth to any of the usual desiderata, including those not necessary for unadorned activity of excellence. Activity of excellence needs more than its status as the prior (indeed, primary) good if it is actually to *make* the other things worth having and getting. The additional condition is that they, too, be at hand. If they are on the scene or in the wings, and if activity of excellence is present or assured, we either have or are set to have all the components of happiness together: the eudaimonic activity, and the items on which it can "act." This sounds like Aristotle's compact formula: "Activity of excellence in a complete life." But perhaps it would be better to think of the *summum bonum* not as happiness, the metaphysical product, but as activity of excellence in the act of *transforming itself into happiness* by taking advantage of available elements which can exist without it and without which it too can exist.

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